

Trump in favor, but Johnson’s bid unsure

Speaker seeks to sway GOP hard-liners ahead of Friday’s vote for gavel

BY MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR

With less than 24 hours to go, Speaker Mike Johnson was still working to win over a handful of Republican lawmakers who are skeptical of his leadership, raising the prospect of a close and contentious vote Friday and increasing the risk that the intra-GOP battles that defined the 118th Congress will continue into the 119th.

Johnson (R-Louisiana) has spent the week working the phones and met with lawmakers in the Capitol through Thursday evening to try to better understand the concerns of roughly half a dozen hard-liners whose support he needs in the speaker-ship election, which begins at noon.

Many of the skeptics come from the ultraconservative House Freedom Caucus, which has spent the past year pushing their leaders to curtail government spending, or else.

To win the gavel Friday, Johnson needs 218 votes if all House lawmakers are present and voting for a speaker candidate by name. Because of the resignation of Rep. Matt Gaetz (R-Florida) last month, House Republicans will start the year with just 219 seats, meaning he can afford to lose just one GOP vote.

Rep. Thomas Massie (R-Kentucky) has said he’ll definitely

SEE JOHNSON ON A4

Biden’s net neutrality rules are overturned

Internet service cannot be regulated in same way utilities can, court says

BY EVA DOU

The U.S. Court of Appeals for the 6th Circuit struck down the FCC’s net neutrality rules governing internet service providers Thursday in an early policy win for Republicans seeking to reverse Biden-era industry regulation.

Democrats at the Federal Communications Commission had considered the reinstatement of net neutrality a major accomplishment under the Biden administration. The reversal is a glimpse of the years ahead, during which President-elect Donald Trump’s team has vowed to broadly undo his predecessor’s regulation of private-sector companies.

The net neutrality issue revolves around how heavily federal regulators should control the companies that build and operate the internet. Democrats favor heavier oversight along the lines of how traditional telephone networks are regulated, while Republicans have argued for a lighter touch. Net neutrality was adopted by the FCC under the Obama administration, reversed under Trump, then reinstated under President Joe Biden.

SEE NET NEUTRALITY ON A14



ANDREW CABALLERO-REYNOLDS/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Security was high outside the Superdome, where the Sugar Bowl took place Thursday evening after being postponed due to the attack.

New Orleans driver likely acted alone

FBI says video shows Army veteran placing coolers with bombs nearby

BY JUSTIN JOUVENAL, LAUREN WEBER AND MARIA SACCHETTI

The Texas man who drove a pickup truck into a New Orleans crowd on New Year’s Day, killing at least 14 people, likely acted alone and had pledged his support to the Islamic State militant group, the FBI said Thursday.

Investigators saw Shamsud-Din Jabbar, 42, an Army veteran, on surveillance video recorded before the attack placing coolers containing improvised explosive devices near the scene of the massacre that also injured at least 35, Christopher Raia, FBI deputy assistant director of counterintelligence, said at a news conference.

Officials have found no definitive link between the New Orleans attack and the explosion of

a Tesla Cybertruck outside a Trump hotel in Las Vegas on Wednesday that killed one person, Raia said. Officials also said there was no longer a threat to the public in New Orleans, where the Sugar Bowl was rescheduled after the attack for Thursday afternoon, instead of Wednesday.

The FBI initially said Wednesday that they thought Jabbar may have had accomplices, but after conducting interviews, examining his phone records and conducting other parts of the investigation, the bureau determined he probably acted alone.

“This was an act of terrorism,” Raia said. “It was premeditated and an evil act.”

Officials offered fresh details about the attack, which unfolded on the popular Bourbon

SEE DRIVER ON A6

Subdued by deadly terror, a city lets the good times roll once more

BY MOLLY HENNESSY-FISKE, TIM CRAIG AND DANIELLE PAQUETTE

NEW ORLEANS — Since a terrorist attack killed at least 14 New Year’s Eve revelers on Bourbon Street and injured dozens more, officials in this city rebuilt on tourism sought to assure the world that it was safe to attend the Sugar Bowl.

The annual college football showdown — postponed a day because of the tragedy — was expected to draw as many as 74,000 fans to the Caesars Superdome on Thursday afternoon, and indeed, the stadium was filled with energy. There was no sign that, 36 hours earlier, leaders had clashed over the right time to resume athletic festivities.

“I am confident the city is

secure,” said Louisiana Attorney General Liz Murrill, who had initially pushed for a lengthier delay. “It does reflect our commitment to not bowing to terrorism.”

New Orleans, famous for its Mardi Gras celebrations, is known for its welcoming allure — and resilience. Fresh off the deadly devastation, that reputation shined through, with crowds flocking back to the storied French Quarter and trombone notes wafting through the cobblestone streets. Locals and guests alike grappled with grief. Many, not all, said the heightened security on display made them feel safer.

And as the game kicked off at 3 p.m., the message was clear: The party must go on, especially with beloved Mardi Gras parades

SEE SAFETY ON A5

Border policy: Trump appears to blame Biden protocols for attack. A6

Jenkins: No public gathering is safe, but we’re braver than we realize. D1

Rebuilding the battle-torn faces — and lives — of Ukrainian troops

The wounds inflicted by Russian weapons resemble those of the two world wars, but treatment has improved dramatically



OKSANA PARAFENIUK FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Surgeons Tetiana Lytvynenko, far right, and Jorge Corona perform oculoplastic surgery on a soldier. Ukraine is seeing so many facial injuries that surgeons from abroad are offering help.

BY SIOBHÁN O’GRADY, KOSTIANTYN KHUDOV AND OKSANA PARAFENIUK

Russian weapons are destroying the faces of Ukraine’s frontline troops.

Supersonic bullets and hails of shrapnel from artillery, glide bombs, drones and mines shatter soldiers’ skulls and jawbones, tear out their eyes, and slash through their cheeks and mouths.

The scale of facial wounds is so severe that experts say it is reminiscent of last century’s world wars, but the technology to treat them has advanced dramatically. Ukrainian doctors and foreign volunteers are building on surgical techniques developed more than 100 years ago.

It is not clear how many facial reconstruction surgeries have been carried out across Ukraine because the government does not disclose the toll of wounded soldiers. But Ukrainian surgeons say their schedules are packed with a constant flood of new patients, whose injuries often evoke shame

in themselves and horror to those around them. Procedures to repair their faces help them rejoin the world.

“Your face is your entryway to life,” said Oleksandr Vasylyev, head of the maxillofacial surgery department at a Kyiv hospital, who treats many of the wounded.

One of his patients, Mykola Rudenok, and several other wounded soldiers receiving treatment in Kyiv allowed Washington Post reporters to observe their medical visits, including some surgeries. Such facial operations can often take 10 hours or more and require advanced 3D models to ensure accuracy.

Meanwhile, the waiting list is growing: Each time fighting at the front intensifies, hospitals become overwhelmed with new facial injuries. Human faces are so sensitive that patients often need multiple procedures over the course of a year or more.

Many of the wounded will never fully heal or look the same again.

SEE UKRAINE ON A11

IN THE NEWS

Fear in Syria The minority Alawite community is gripped by terror as reports spread of killings and disappearances under the country’s new Islamist rulers. A9

Plowly McPlowface The D.C. region is bracing for snow with salt, beet juice and colorfully named plows, thanks to an online contest. B1

THE NATION President Joe Biden will create two monuments in California honoring Native tribes. A2
Scientists studied magma as they puzzled over the likelihood of a Yellowstone eruption. A3

THE WORLD In beef-dominated Argentina, economic hardships are making pork increasingly popular. A8
Israel launched more than 15 strikes on Gaza City, with over 40 people reported killed. A9

THE ECONOMY A gas company’s plans to restart a defunct pipeline near a California beach that has seen two major oil spills has residents fighting back. A13
Tesla reported its first yearly drop in electric vehicle deliveries in over a decade. A14

THE REGION Trayon White Sr., who’s facing a bribery charge, apologizes as he’s sworn in to the D.C. Council — without saying why. B1
On Christmas Day in 2023, Shawn Wilkerson was shot. Last month, he and his wife leased an apartment in D.C. B1

STYLE Classical music has found an unlikely home on TikTok through memes, tutorials and performance clips. C1

WEEKEND The nine best places to eat in Silver Spring, a melting pot of global cuisines just seven miles from the White House.

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